FLEET TEAM DIGEST

737MAX-FTD-27-17002

Issue Title : Inadvertent Activation of Rudder Trim

Airplane Model	ATA	Minor Model(s)
737MAX	2721-00	-7, -8, -8200, -9, -BBJ

Other Model(s)	ECCN
737, 737NG	9E991

Originated Date	Last Revised Date	Created On
05/10/2017	05/10/2017	03/24/2017

Estimated Completion Date	Next Update Date

Applicability

All 737 aircraft equipped with the secure flight deck door.

Description

The purpose of this article is to notify operators of the potential for confusion of the rudder trim knob and the secure flight deck door knob located on the aisle stand. This letter contains an event description where a pilot mistook the rudder trim knob for the door knob, Boeing action in response to the event, and operator recommendations to prevent any future occurrences.

Background

A 737-700 pilot operated the rudder trim when intending to unlock the flight deck door. The rudder trim actuation resulted in a significant airplane upset event that was recovered by the pilot. Airplane roll due to the rudder deflection was initially countered by the autopilot with an opposite wheel command. The autopilot reached its authority limit, and the airplane began to roll. The pilot intervened as the airplane bank angle exceeded 50 degrees. The airplane reached a bank angle of 131 degrees, lost approximately 6,000 feet of altitude, and underwent a heading change of 155 degrees during the recovery. The pilot did not disconnect the autopilot during the event, but instead overrode the control wheel causing the autopilot to transition to the Control Wheel Steering (CWS) roll mode.

Status

Boeing released FOTB 737-12-2 in June-2012, to provide increased flight crew awareness of the Upset Recovery non-normal maneuver and the instruction to disconnect the autopilot and autothrottle.

Boeing sent Multi-Operator Message, MOM-MOM-12-0489-01B, to the 737 fleet in July-2012, to communicate the potential for unintended rudder trim inputs.

In a review of the aisle stand switch layout of the incident airplane, Boeing identified a potential for confusion between the rudder trim control and the secure flight deck door lock release switch on 737-600/-700/-800/-900 and 737-300/-400/-500 models. Because of the commonality in electronic panels, this potential confusion between the rudder trim control and the secure flight deck door lock release switch may also be evident on 737 MAX 7/8/8200/9 models. This is due to:

1. Variability in switch locations on the aisle stands across the airline fleet.

-In the incident 737-700 airplane, the rudder trim control is in approximately the same location as the secure flight deck door lock

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switch (installed by Supplemental Type Certificate) in the operator's 737-500.

2. Similarity of the switch operation.

-Although the door lock release switch requires a unique push action before turning, both switches require a final action of turn and hold.

Interim Action

None.

Final Action

Operators may wish to consider taking steps to reduce the potential for inadvertent rudder trim activation, such as the following:

1. Establishing an internal policy that another crew member is required to be on the flight deck when only a single pilot remains on the flight deck. Note that there are other advantages to having an additional person on the flight deck, e.g., in case of pilot incapacitation or illness.

2. Awareness training for flight crews about the possibility of unintended operation of a flight deck control, including the need for visual identification prior to operating a control.

3. Ensuring that there are no configurations where the rudder trim control in one airplane is in the same location as the door lock switch in another airplane. This may increase the likelihood of pilots operating the rudder trim control when intending to operate the door lock switch. If such configurations are found, operators may wish to take steps to reduce the likelihood of this error, such as changing the aisle stand layout so that switch locations are consistent and advising crews to visually verify the control before operating it.

4. The FAA has issued the referenced Special Airworthiness Information Bulletin (SAIB) recommending operators use Flight Deck procedures and make the aisle stand configuration standard in their fleet.

Reference Categories

Reference Type	Reference Number	Revision Number	Reference Date
Multi-Operator Message (MOM)	MOM-MOM-12-0489-01B		
Flight Operations Technical Bulletin (FOTB)	737-12-2		
Other	FAA SAIB NM-15-03		11/24/2014
Service Letter (SL)	737-SL-27-238		

Related Categories

- In Service Occurrences : null
- SRPs - Safety : Service Related Problems in work by Boeing that have an airplane or personal safety impact

Attachments:

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a) 737 Rudder Trim & Door Knobs

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